Ringworm (Tinea)

A contagious fungal skin infection needs antifungal treatment

ABOUT THIS TOPIC

Ringworm is a fungal infection, not a worm. It may appear as an itchy, enlarging scaly patch, but not every ring-shaped rash is ringworm. A clinician or pharmacist can help confirm what it is.

Everyday care and treatment

- For ringworm on the skin, use an antifungal medicine as directed on its label or by a health professional; treatment commonly takes 2 to 4 weeks.
- Keep the area clean and dry. Wash hands after touching it, do not share towels or clothing, and wash items that touch the rash.
- Do not use steroid cream alone on a suspected fungal infection. Steroids can hide or worsen the infection.
- Scalp or nail infection often needs clinician assessment and prescription treatment; skin creams alone may not be enough.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Seek clinical advice if the rash is on the scalp or nails, is widespread, worsens, returns, or does not improve with correctly used antifungal treatment. Get advice sooner for a young child or a person with a weakened immune system.

Sources for further reading

US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention - Ringworm treatment - https://www.cdc.gov/ringworm/treatment/

US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention - Ringworm basics - https://www.cdc.gov/ringworm/about/

Reviewed for this educational handout: October 2026. Recommendations can change and depend on local guidance, age, pregnancy, other health conditions, and medicines. This handout is not a diagnosis or prescription.